Los Angeles Times

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ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

HOMES IN Los Angeles County sold for 66.8% higher than those in L.A.'s surrounding suburbs in June.

Homes still far pricier in L.A. than in suburbs

Angelenos pay highest premium in U.S., data show

By Terry Castleman

To hear the skeptics tell it, Los Angeles County is far from prime real estate these days.

Surveys of residents reveal deep dissatisfaction about the quality of life. Data show Los Angeles County's population dropping even as other places rebound.

But when it come to real estate values, the center core of Los Angeles County still holds a major advantage over its fast-growing suburbs, according to a Times data analysis.

In fact, the gap in price between Los Angeles' center and its far-flung suburbs is greater than those of many other major cities, an analysis based on data from the real estate company Redfin found.

Homes in Los Angeles County sold for 66.8% higher than in L.A.'s surrounding suburbs in June, according to the data. For this analysis, the suburbs were Riverside, San Bernardino and Ventura counties. Orange County, where average home prices are higher than Los Angeles County's, boasts bustling job centers and was counted as its own urban area.

Across the nation's 21 biggest metropolitan areas, Los Angeles ranked first in price premium compared with suburbs, just edging out New York City, the data showed.

On a price-per-square-foot basis, the difference is starker: Homebuyers in the core of Los Angeles (as defined by Redfin) pay an 84.7% premium over those purchasing in surrounding areas.

In Phoenix, homes in the city center cost 27% more than in the suburbs and exurbs, the third-highest value of any major city. In Dallas-Fort Worth, the premium was just 11%. And in Denver, San Antonio and Detroit, suburban homes were actually more valuable than homes in the city proper.

After the COVID-19 pandemic, return-to-office policies shifted prices up in city centers around the country, said Daryl Fairweather, Redfin's chief economist. Additionally, she said, "soaring gas prices make living in car-dependent suburbs more expensive

[See **Homes,** A6]

META GETS BIG PENALTY OVER PRIVACY

N.M. judge orders $25-billion payout for misleading Facebook users on safeguards.

BY QUEENIE WONG

Meta, the parent company of Facebook, was ordered by a New Mexico judge on Wednesday to pay $25 billion for misleading users about how it collects and safeguards user data.

The penalty, one of the largest ever levied against Meta or any other company, is the latest legal hit to the social media giant, which has grappled with lawsuits over allegations of social media addiction and child safety.

New Mexico sued the company in 2021 after revelations surfaced that a U.K. political consulting firm had harvested millions of Facebook users' personal data without their consent. The major data privacy scandal sparked more scrutiny of Facebook and led to lawsuits, congressional hearings and multibillion-dollar fines.

A New Mexico jury dealt a blow to Meta, previously named Facebook, in September, finding that the social media company committed 43 million violations of the state's consumer protection laws by making false and misleading statements about data privacy protections and efforts to combat misinformation and hate speech.

[See **Facebook,** A11]

Bipartisan furor grows as Trump pressures Ukraine

His overtures to Putin just weeks before midterms alarm U.S. lawmakers and public.

BY MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — President Trump's latest embrace of Russian President Vladimir Putin is deepening alarm in Washington and among America's allies that the White House pressure campaign could leave Ukraine vulnerable as Moscow advances.

Trump's push to end the war, which has raged since 2022, comes on the cusp of a midterm election that could give Democrats partial or full control of Congress, expanding their oversight powers, and as polls show more than two-thirds of Americans disapprove of the president's handling of foreign policy and support Kyiv's fight against Russian aggression.

On Monday, Trump dismissed Russia's ongoing assault on its neighbor, telling reporters that "they haven't been doing much," even as Russian forces bombed a park in Kharkiv that day, killing a mother and her 14-month-old child in her stroller.

Two days later, in St. Petersburg, Trump's special envoy, Steve Witkoff, described Putin as a "humanitarian," despite his invasion unleashing Europe's deadliest conflict since World War II.

"You talk so much about my president, President Trump, being a humanitarian. You are a humanitarian also, sir," Witkoff said after securing the release of a detained U.S. citizen from the Kremlin. At least two other Americans, both from Los Angeles, remain wrongfully detained by Russia. "I salute you, and I commend you," he added.

Rep. Don Bacon (R-Neb.) described Witkoff's re-

[See **Ukraine,** A7]

American jailed in Russia is released

Stephen Hubbard was held captive over four years on disputed mercenary charges. **WORLD, A2**



ANNA MONEYMAKER Getty Images

MOST Americans disapprove of Trump's foreign policy. Above, he campaigns in South Carolina.

SpaceX, Tesla might merge

Elon Musk says the aerospace firm and electric car maker are considering a tie-up.

BY LAURENCE DARMIENTO AND CAROLINE PETROW-COHEN

One company makes electric cars that are inherently terrestrial, ferrying millions of drivers on roads around the world. The other shoots rockets into space and has aspirations to make it to Mars. At first glance, they would seem like an odd pairing.

Yet, this week Elon Musk said that aerospace firm SpaceX and EV carmaker Tesla — two trailblazing companies he built and serves over as chief executive — were considering a tie-up, confirming speculation that what would be the biggest corporate merger ever is a real possibility.

And like much else on Wall Street, the driving force apparently is artificial intelligence, including demands for massive infrastructure spending to support its vast computing power.

Although Tesla's best-selling Model Y and Model 3 require drivers to get behind the wheel, the company has developed an autonomous ride-hailing vehicle called a Cybercab with no human controls that has just begun pilot testing. Musk sees it and a robot called Optimus as keys to the future of Tesla, which will rely on vast cloud computing power that it and SpaceX already are developing together.

"This is a strategic no brainer for Musk and the SpaceX ecosystem to merge with Tesla," analyst Dan Ives, a partner Yorkville Ives & Co., said in an email.

But even if the deal makes strategic sense, there are myriad practical challenges in combining two trillion-dollar companies with vastly different operations — as well as regulatory concerns that are not just do-

[See **Merger,** A11]

SOARING PROFITS: SpaceX touts $4.4 billion in net income. **BUSINESS, A9**

Lawsuit alleges threat to election

California immigrant, Democrats accuse Trump administration of meddling in vote.

BY KEVIN RECTOR

Top Democrats in Congress have joined a California immigrant and the Nevada State Democratic Party in suing the Trump administration over its unprecedented voter fraud probes in both states and broader efforts to meddle in state-run elections nationwide — alleging they are a "pretext to seize control over elections."

The lawsuit, filed in federal court in Washington late Tuesday, accuses President Trump, Homeland Security Secretary Markwayne Mullin, Atty. Gen. Todd Blanche and the agencies they lead of using "shoddily compiled lists of supposed noncitizens" and "coercive threats of legal retaliation against state officials" to assert federal control over the Nov. 3 midterms.

In addition to Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer, House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries and several national Democratic groups, the plaintiffs include Erick Jose Jimenez, an "active California voter" and naturalized U.S. citizen since 2006 who now "fears that he will be unlawfully targeted for voting and disenfranchised (or worse)" given the Trump administration's track record of misidentifying naturalized citizens as noncitizens.

Lauren Bis, a White House spokesperson, said in a statement that while "Democrats and the media continue to dismiss concerns about voter fraud, the Trump Administration is taking decisive lawful action to protect our elections," including by "prosecuting election crimes, strengthening election infrastructure security, and protecting vulnerable voters from fraud and coercion."

[See **Election,** A7]

Small ballot error, massive outcry

Furor over duplicates sent to Tulare voters is a sign of fraught election climate. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

A swim down state's coast into history

Californian traverses all 900 miles, El Niño perils included

By Iris Kwok

As the California coast endured a year of El Niño, hurricane threats, destructive waves and record warm water temperatures, Catherine Breed set out to make history.

At the Oregon border, she got into the water and began a journey to swim the entire stretch of the state coastline — roughly 900 miles.

It took months and required detours around sharks, crab traps, storms and a polluted river.

On Monday, the 33-year-old endurance swimmer emerged from the water after crossing the latitude of the California-Mexico border and became the first person to swim the length of California.

"It just felt emotional," Breed told The Times on Tuesday, calling from San Diego. "I felt so proud of the team, and definitely a mix of joy but also relief that it was over and we did it successfully."

Breed technically finished her journey from Oregon to Mexico in private three miles offshore to avoid the sewage and pollution crisis from the Tijuana River.

To cap off the 111-day journey, which began in July, Breed held a celebration at Coronado Beach on Monday. She swam from the open sea toward shore and climbed onto the sand, where guests had been encouraged to "stay dry and cheer loud from the beach."

Breed was raised in Pleasanton, Calif., and is a UC Berkeley graduate,

[See **Swim,** A6]



PAUL KURODA For The Times

CATHERINE BREED trains in February for her swim along California's coast. She finished in 111 days.

An ugly campaign turn in Ohio

Republican candidate for governor boosts ad with rival's mother, to bipartisan disgust. **NATION, A4**

Microplastics' health threat

Water contact triggers a cell-damaging reaction, which may cause illness, study finds. **SCIENCE, A8**

Where trees go after forest fires

A biologist turns detective to follow logging trucks from the Sierra. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Thunderstorms.
L.A. Basin: 69/58. **B6**

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